

Steven Spielberg's *Jaws* ushers in **the era of the blockbuster**, and is a box-office triumph.

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1975

Taxi Driver and *All the President's Men* reflect the psychological scars of the **Vietnam War** and the **Watergate** scandal, respectively.

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1976

Star Wars takes **science fiction** and **franchising** into a whole new galaxy, while Spielberg thrills again with *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*.

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1977

Two epic turns usher in the 1980s: Jack Nicholson in Kubrick's **psycho-horror** *The Shining* and Robert De Niro in Scorsese's **boxing biopic** *Raging Bull*.

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1980

1975

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Video recorders go mainstream as Betamax and (one year later) VHS long-play formats enable moviegoers to record and play movies at home.

1977

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New York inspires both Woody Allen's wry look at love in *Annie Hall* and the disco inferno that is *Saturday Night Fever*.

1979

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Science fiction veers from **crazed dystopias** in *Stalker* and *Mad Max* to all-out horror in *Alien*, while *Apocalypse Now* lays bare the horrors of war.

1981

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While *Raiders of the Lost Ark* launches the **Indiana Jones** franchise, a German U-boat stalks its prey in *Das Boot*.

After the major upheavals of the Swinging Sixties, the 1970s saw a different kind of revolution unfold. For all the tremors at their foundations, it seemed Hollywood's big studios were still standing, but now a new kind of movie burst onto the scene.

Director Steven Spielberg was, like so many of his peers, a young, movie-literate hotshot. But deep down he was also an old-fashioned showman. In the classic Hollywood tradition of happy accidents and unlikely triumphs, the production of *Jaws* was cursed by a man-eating great white shark that Spielberg felt was so laughably unrealistic he could barely bring himself to put it on screen. And yet it became the hit that changed the movies, installing a new type of blockbuster at the top of the food chain.

Two years later, when George Lucas's *Star Wars* came along to capture the imagination of a generation, the movie business was further transformed. Entering the world of Wookies and Jedi would become a rite of passage for each new generation of moviegoers, but Lucas's success also meant that soon, for Hollywood, there was no such thing as mere movies any more—only franchises in waiting.

And yet this was also a time when some of cinema's finest minds made their most audacious and enduring movies. In America, after *Chinatown's* definitive portrait of LA's murky backstory, the spotlight now fell brilliantly and unforgivingly on New York. By the mid 1970s, Martin Scorsese had already announced himself as a giant talent—but *Taxi Driver*

(starring Robert De Niro as cabbie and ex-Marine Travis Buckle) would be the first of Scorsese's masterworks, a dazed snapshot of paranoia and urban decay that became an instant time capsule.

Alvy Singer was the hero and neurotic narrator of another consummate New York story: Woody Allen's romantic comedy, *Annie Hall*. For years to come, rare was the movie that wasn't in debt to one of those characters and its creators.

Beyond Hollywood

Outside America, ambiguity throbbed at the heart of movies that once seen, would be impossible to ignore. From Australia, in the same year that Spielberg's shark thrilled audiences in *Jaws*, director Peter Weir made *Picnic at Hanging Rock*,